Kashmir. More to the point, of the 90 seats now allocated to J&K, Jammu's share has gone up from 37 to 43, bringing it closer to Kashmir's tally, which is now just four more at 47.

Jammu's Kishtwar, Samba, Kathua, Rajouri, Doda and Reasi get an additional seat each, with a new one for Kashmir's Kupwara district. Instead of relying only on the population—usually the main criterion for delimitations—the commission has also considered geography, topography and proximity to the international border. In Jammu, each constituency has a population of about 125,000, while in Kashmir the figure is 145,000. The panel has also recommended reserving seven seats for scheduled castes and nine seats for scheduled tribes.

However, the exercise has not gone down well with locals, with simmering discontent even in Jammu, which some consider a BJP bastion. Choudhary Lal Singh, a Dogra leader and former BJP minister, says the delimitation exercise was wrong from the very beginning. Unimpressed by the six new seats for Jammu, the founder of the Dogra Swabhiman Sangathan, who has been raising emotive issues of Dogra identity, says Jammu should instead have 20 new seats. He cites the case of Kashmiri Pandits who are mainly based in Jammu, saying they should have seats there, also arguing that the 24 seats reserved for PoK should be distributed among those from Jammu.

Some argue the political furore over the draft delimitation plays into the BJP's hands, and that the saffron party is looking to delay assembly elections. J&K Panthers Party chairman Harshdev Singh says, "In the name of delimitation, they are delaying assembly elections. The BJP doesn't want a democratically elected government here and wants to continue ruling through proxies." The delimitation panel, the former minister suggests, should have given an equal number of seats to Jammu and Kashmir to settle "historical injustice". Even senior members of the BJP are not entirely pleased with the commission's recommendations—former speaker of the legislative assembly and BJP leader Kavinder Gupta says that displaced residents from PoK who have settled in Jammu should be given reservations from the 24 seats reserved for PoK.

In Kashmir, people highlight the communal polarisation at the heart of the delimitation exercise. They point out that if population is the main criterion, Kashmir should have been given 51 seats—in this context, the granting of six new seats to Jammu and only one to Kashmir is being seen as an attempt to tilt the political power balance from Kashmir to Jammu. The BJP has a long-standing aspiration of seeing a Hindu chief minister in J&K, and the additional seats for Jammu are being seen as a step in this direction. Masoodi sees this development as a next step in the disempowerment of Kashmir after the abrogation of Article 370 on August 5, 2019. The entire exercise, he says, is questionable and lacks constitutional validity since there are petitions challenging the August 5 move in the Supreme Court. "We told the commission that the delimitation exercise is illegal and the J&K Reorganisation Act is a constitutionally-suspect law," he says. "The panel had no answer and we were told to file an objection [to the commission]."

THE ALLOCATION OF SEATS HAS NOT GONE DOWN WELL, WITH RESENTMENT EVEN IN JAMMU, A BJP STRONGHOLD

The objection prepared by the NC has listed several reasons to reject the exercise. For one, it questions delimitation being conducted in J&K when there is a broad freeze on such exercises being conducted in the rest of India until 2026. It has also questioned the criteria on which the delimitation has been conducted, saying that population—usually the primary consideration for such an exercise—has been given lower importance in order to favour Jammu over Kashmir. It also cites the case of Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, pointing out that after Telangana was created in 2014, the Andhra Pradesh Reorganisation Act increased the number of assembly seats in both states (from 119 to 153 in Telangana and 175 to 225 in Andhra Pradesh) without conducting a delimitation. Union Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai said in Parliament on August 3 last year that the Centre would take up the delimitation in these states after 2026. "If elections can be held in Telangana without delimitation, the urgency to carve out new constituencies in J&K is transparent to all," says Masoodi.

Sunil Dimple, a political activist from Jammu, says his fears have come true after the delimitation commission's recommendations were made public, arguing it has nothing to offer to either Jammu or Kashmir. "We rejected the report outright," he says. Dimple boycotted the meeting of the commission during its four-day interaction with political parties, leaders, civil society groups and officials between July 4 and July 9 last year. He believes the exercise should have been conducted according to Census 2021 and that seats should have been distributed in parity to both regions. "*Yeh barbaadi ka raasta hai* (This is a route to destruction)," says Dimple, who heads Mission Statehood, an organisation working for the restoration of J&K's statehood. "What is the hurry to carry out this exercise?" The delimitation, he says, is a small issue and the larger problem is the demographic change coming from the government's new policy of leasing land to non-local investors. "Agricultural land is being allotted for commercial activities. They want to destroy our culture and identity. We welcome investors, but not at the cost of our demography." ■